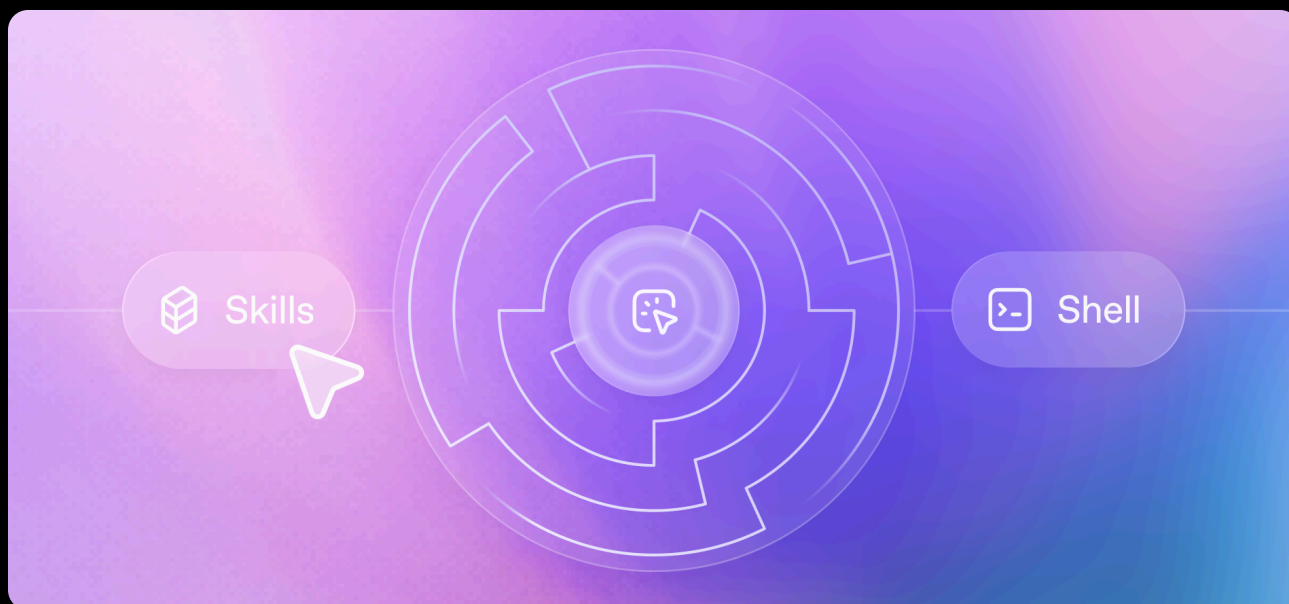


Feb 11, 2026 API

Shell + Skills + Compaction: Tips for long-running agents that do real work

Practical patterns for building with skills, hosted shell, and server-side compaction in the Responses API.

Author: Charlie Guo



We're shifting from single-turn assistants to long-running agents that handle real knowledge work: reading large datasets, updating files, and writing apps.

Based on developer feedback and our own experience building Codex and internal agents, we're releasing a new set of agentic primitives that make long-horizon work more practical:

- **Skills** (aligned with the Agent Skills open standard): reusable, versioned instructions you can mount into containers so that agents can execute tasks more reliably.
- Upgraded **shell** tool: an OpenAI hosted container with controlled internet access, where an agent can install dependencies, run scripts, and write outputs (for example, reports and artifacts).

Ask AI